Times/Siena poll points to a good night for Democrats

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【メール原文】

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Times/Siena poll points to a good night for Democrats. The marquee New York Times/Siena College poll is out today with surveys of the South Carolina, Florida, and Minnesota race, all suggesting that Democrats are favorites to flip the Senate.

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The most attention-grabbing result is that the race in South Carolina is tied at 48% each for the Democrat and Republican candidates. While a number of recent polls have found the South Carolina race to be surprisingly close, this is the first non-partisan poll showing it actually tied, suggesting Republican Sen. Darlene Graham's weaknesses are a candidate are still dragging her down.

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Among independents, Graham has an image problem: only 35% of independents view her favorably, compared to 57% for the Democrat, Annie Andrews. That could be decisive as wavering voters decide in the final days.

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The Minnesota poll might be even better news for Democrats. It places the Democratic lead there at 14 points, far larger than the roughly five-point lead in recent polling, which was too close for comfort for Democrats in one of their "blue wall" seats.

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The Times/Siena topline, though out of step with other recent polls, is sensible: Minnesota voted for Kamala Harris by 4 points in 2024, so it should lean about 14 points toward Democrats this year, given the 10-point shift in the national environment.

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Florida still looks out of reach for Democrats: Republicans lead there by six points, reduced from their 13-point margin in 2024 but likely too heavy a lift for Democrat Angie Nixon.

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These numbers across the board support the view that Democrats are at least the moderate favorites to flip the Senate next week and suggest that the campaign in its final days may be breaking in their direction. There has been no relief on the macro level for Republicans: President Trump's approval ratings still hovering around 37%, his net approval of -23% is roughly twice as negative as ahead of the 2018 midterms,

US-Iran escalation likely in mid-November. The US will likely launch new military strikes against Iran (65% odds, unchanged) after the midterms, potentially with Israel's support. We see pre-midterm escalation as unlikely given the political downside and time needed to prepare for new strikes.

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The strikes will likely be brief and intense, focused on strategic targets like Iran's underground missile and unclear facilities. The US or Israel could also strike civilian and energy infrastructure. Weakening Iran, degrading its military capabilities, and pressuring its leaders to accept US demands will be the main goals.

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Iran is not prepared to submit, though. Its leadership's capacity to absorb pain remains considerable, and Iran possesses large quantities of short-range missiles and drones that can be used against regional targets. Iran will likely target US bases, military assets, and energy infrastructure if attacked, and may target regional infrastructure like undersea cables and data centers.

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A breakthrough in negotiations remains unlikely (20% odds). A minimal arrangement, where Iran would halt attacks in the Strait of Hormuz and agree to new nuclear discussions, is possible. In return the US would drop its blockade and permit Iran to export oil again.

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For more, please see The US will likely strike Iran in mid-November , 27 October 2026.

White House has no good options for disrupting midterms. We do not expect serious disruptions to the midterm elections. Concerns that the Trump administration may attempt to do so are not ill-founded, but we do not expect the administration to try to subvert the results of the election, and we expect any efforts to do so to fail. The White House cares more about creating an illegitimacy narrative over the elections than actually preventing Democrats from taking power (see "DOJ election suits aim to create illegitimacy narrative ," US Daily, 26 October 2026).

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A serious attempt by current elected officials to deny House election results or certification would be the most concerning development, as well as competing slates of election victors from one state or the outright defiance of court orders requiring certification.

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Vote delays, recounts, and legal challenges are normal parts of the election process. More concerning would be attempts to disqualify large swathes of mail-in ballots, the presence of federal law enforcement at election sites, or federal moves against mail-in ballots or voting machines in the final days of campaigning; in all these cases we expect near-certain court pushback would be effective.

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Politics will also check any attempts to overturn the election. Democrats will likely flip enough seats to make denying their majority through election certifications too difficult; Trump largely does not care about losing Congress; and any attempts to overturn election results would require near-unanimous GOP support.

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For more, please see White House has no good options for midterm disruptions , 27 October 2026.

Quote of the Day

“I think for every young, female, non-white voter AOC turns out in Florida, she probably also turns out 1.2 anti-socialist Sunshine State boomers" - Former Rep. Matt Gaetz speaking to Politico. Rep. Alexandra Ocasio-Cortez (D-NY) has made midterm appearances in several competitive states, including Florida, where she is supporting fellow progressive Angie Nixon, and Democratic midterm voters in recent polling have ranked her among the top tier of campaign surrogates, alongside Barack Obama and Bernie Sanders. Republicans hope that her campaigning will have the opposite effect, driving out GOP voters more than Democrats.

On the Radar

30-31 October: G20 Foreign Ministers' meeting

3 November: National midterm elections

9 November: Congress returns from recess

18-19 November: APEC leaders meeting in China

11 December: Government funding runs out

14-15 December: G20 summit in Florida

10 January: US-China tariff truce expires

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